Akbar lent to the Jesuits the European books that he had acquired over the years. The books included the works of Pope Sylvester, of Cardinal Cajetan, the Chronicles of Saint Francis, the History of the Popes, the Laws of Portugal, the Commentaries of Alfonso Albuquerque, the works of Saint Ignatius, and a Latin Grammar book. Fragments of European books travelled extensively through Hindustan at this time, sometimes finding themselves in unusual surroundings. The Jesuits wrote of a Hindu raja in 1648 who was a proud possessor of a brightly illumined Portuguese book, which he had fondly hoped contained the secrets of alchemy. When the Fathers explained that it was a holy book, it caused, not altogether surprisingly, ‘great disappointment’.

At court, too, Akbar showed the Jesuits exceptional kindness, sometimes making them share the royal takht with him. They noticed with pleasure that Akbar sometimes wore a reliquary around his neck, suspended by a gold chain, which had on ‘one side of it an Agnus Dei, and on the other an image of our Lady’. The Jesuits described a court which had altered and become more rigid since the time the bemused Persian merchant Rafiuddin had struggled to distinguish the young and debonair Padshah from his clamouring youthful companions many decades earlier. Now the courtiers and amirs maintained a respectful distance and an attentive posture before the Padshah; where they stood in court depended on their rank. All officers, unless specifically exempted, were to be present at court. The greatest punishment for an amir was to be forbidden attendance at the darbar of the Padshah. At the darbar, the more elegant among the amirs stood with the fingertips of the left hand touching their right elbow or vice versa, and they sometimes also crossed the right foot over the left, with the toes of the right foot lightly touching the ground. When Muzaffar Hussain Mirza* arrived at court to surrender Kandahar in 1595, he prostrated himself several times before the Mughal Padshah before inching his way forward on the carpet and placing his head at Akbar’s feet. Many of the new measures had been devised by Akbar in order to curtail his ambitious and wealthy courtiers by ensuring suitable deference.

The treasures now being offered to Akbar were dazzling. Although Kandahar was but a small city, it was a wealthy one as it was on the main trade route between India and Persia. Its fortress would serve as an excellent frontier base, making the Mughal Empire a truly Asian one. Muzaffar Hussain Mirza also presented the Padshah a pair of swords,